

Λιβάνιος ὁ Ἀντιοχεύς

Libanius of Antioch and the Orations of Late Antiquity

eul_aid: swk

Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία [Late Antique](#)

Dialect: Ἀττικίζουσα [Atticizing](#)

Domain: Ῥητορική [Oratory](#)

Format: Λόγος [Oration](#)

Libanius was a Greek teacher and public speaker in the 4th century CE. He was born in the city of Antioch in 314 CE and died there, likely around 393 CE. A committed pagan, he lived during a time when Christianity was becoming the dominant religion of the Roman Empire. He was a leading figure of the Second Sophistic, a cultural movement focused on reviving classical Greek rhetoric and style.

He founded and ran a highly successful school of rhetoric in his hometown, attracting students from across the eastern empire, including future prominent Christian bishops. Despite his pagan beliefs, he maintained complex relationships with powerful Christian officials and emperors. He was a close friend and supporter of the pagan emperor Julian.

Libanius was an exceptionally prolific writer. A large body of his work survives, including over 1,600 personal letters, 64 formal speeches, and many rhetorical exercises. His speeches cover a wide range of topics, from autobiography and imperial praise to legal petitions and local politics.

Modern scholars consider Libanius a witness of paramount importance. His vast collection of letters and orations provides an unparalleled, detailed view into the social life, education, politics, and religious tensions of the 4th-century eastern Roman Empire. His career demonstrates how classical Greek education remained a powerful source of status and influence, even as the cultural and religious landscape changed around him.

Works (11)

- Προοίμια Δημοσθένους Λόγων · [Arguments of Demosthenic Orations](#) · 223 passages
- Ἀλληλογραφία Βασιλείου καὶ Λιβανίου · [Correspondence of Basil and Libanius](#) · 70 passages
- Μελέτη γ · [Declamation 3, Embassy of Menelaus, Theorem](#) · 4 passages
- Μελέται Α'–ΝΑ' · [Declamations 1–51](#) · 2459 passages
- Ἐπιστολιμαῖοι χαρακτῆρες · [Epistolary Styles](#) · 70 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Ἀρετῆς · [Fragments on Virtue](#) · 13 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Μελετῶν · [Fragments-Declamations](#) · 11 passages
- Ἐπιστολαί · [Letters](#) · 4636 passages
- Λόγοι 1–64 · [Orations 1–64](#) · 2934 passages
- Προγυμνάσματα · [Preliminary Exercises](#) · 1107 passages
- Ψευδεπίγραφα Ἐπιστολαί · [Pseudepigraphal Letters](#) · 24 passages